

TECHNOLOGY IS THE FUTURE

Bejul Somaia, Senior Leader at Lightspeed Venture Partners and Partner, Global, swears by the future of technology in India. After all, the portfolio companies mentioned above have technology at the heart of their existence, whatever be the end product they are selling.

Sitting in Lightspeed India's sleek new offices in Bengaluru's upscale Indiranagar, Somaia posed a hypothetical question and proceeded to answer it himself.

"If I think about a decade from now in India, an economy like this, will technology be more prevalent in this country or less? It will be far more prevalent. I have no doubt about that," he said.

A successful IPO will mark the culmination of an eventful journey in India for Lightspeed, and the road ahead offers an opportunity to take stock of how it—and the VC ecosystem—has grown in the country.

For over two decades, Lightspeed Venture Partners has been shaping the global start-up ecosystem. Its tryst with India started in 2007, with early bets for instance in IEX, a power trading platform for physical delivery of electricity.

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What started as investments by Lightspeed's global pool soon evolved into the dedicated arm, backing ventures across India and Southeast Asia. Since then, the investor has pumped \$2.3 billion into Indian start-ups, delivering stellar returns, sometimes as high as 30x, from select portfolio companies.

Traditionally known for its seed-stage focus—underwriting modest investments in early-stage start-ups—it has steadily transformed into a growth-stage investor, signing cheques worth tens of millions of dollars.

Its first big leap into this arena came with OYO in 2015 and since then, the bets have only become bolder. From quick commerce to fintech and edtech, and the business-to-business (B2B) space to, more recently, artificial intelligence (AI), Lightspeed's fingerprint is now visible across India's most dynamic sectors.

In 2023, it backed Sarvam, one of the first start-ups selected under the IndiaAI Mission to build a foundational AI model—a clear signal of Lightspeed's confidence in India's deep-tech potential.

From identifying a promising start-up to hearing its pitch, backing it, and eventually strategising exits—a lot happens behind the scenes. But is it a one-man call or a collective effort?

Harsha Kumar, Partner at Lightspeed, says decisions are never taken in isolation. "Yes, formally the six part-

CHANGING WITH THE TIMES

► Traditionally a seed-stage investor, Lightspeed has evolved into a growth-stage powerhouse

► It has built an over \$2.3 billion fund strategy, delivering stellar returns, sometimes up to 30x

► From OYO, Zepto, and PhysicsWallah to Razorpay and Sarvam AI, Lightspeed is behind some sector-defining start-ups

► Unlike some marquee peers, Lightspeed has largely sidestepped governance crises

► Despite big wins, Lightspeed India still awaits a blockbuster IPO—expected from PhysicsWallah, OYO, or Zetwerk by 2026

ners take the call, but when a founder walks into the investment committee, it isn't just us in the room. Close to 20 people—from platform and talent to finance, marketing, legal, and portfolio support—join in, ensuring every perspective is heard."

This agility set Lightspeed apart at a time when marquee investors such as Tiger Global, SoftBank, Accel and Prosus either slowed investments or grappled with setbacks at some star portfolio firms—think Byju's, the online coaching institute that is undergoing insolvency proceedings, or Good Glamm, the seller of personal